

BEFORE THE GODS

A Treatment

Written by Doug Olear

Adult Animated Feature Film · 75–80 Minutes

Heightened Photorealism · PG-13 · \$25–40 Million

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LOGLINE

Across 70,000 years of human history — from the first fire on the African savanna to a teenager holding his grandmother's hand in a modern hospital room — one question has never been answered.

It has never stopped being asked.

THE FILM

Before the Gods is an adult animated feature film spanning eleven civilizations across 70,000 years — the full sweep of humanity's search for meaning, from the first act of grief at the edge of a fire to the religions that now shape the lives of eight billion people.

It is not a documentary. It is not a polemic. It is a cinematic experience — rendered in heightened photorealism, scored for full orchestra, told with the depth and emotional honesty of prestige drama.

Its subject is not religion. Its subject is the question religion was invented to answer.

This is not a movie about whether God exists. It is a movie about why human beings cannot stop asking.

THE FRAME STORY

The film opens and closes in the present day. MONICA — a woman in her eighties — lies in a hospital room, dying. On the windowsill, a small Buddha figurine nobody quite remembers bringing. A rosary in her daughter's hands. A cross on the wall.

Her grandson THEO, seventeen, sits beside her. Phone face-down. Not looking away.

When Monica asks him — quietly, in what will be her last conversation — "Do you believe in anything?" — Theo has no answer.

She closes her eyes. Her monitor flatlines. And then — impossibly — the flat electronic tone bends and deepens and becomes something older than electronics, older than hospitals, older than any room a human being has ever died in.

A single human voice. Wordless. Ancient. Low.

The Milky Way blazes open across the screen. And we are taken back 70,000 years.

When we return to Theo in the epilogue, he is holding his grandmother's hand in the stillness of her room. Outside the window: a parking lot, streetlights — and above them, a few stars. The same stars Kael looked up at 70,000 years ago.

The score rebuilds from a single voice to a full orchestral chorus of every tradition humanity has ever carried — and then strips back, one by one, to silence. One star. Held.

The question Kael asked beside a fire 70,000 years ago has never been answered. It has never stopped being asked.

STRUCTURE

The film moves in two large movements. A Prologue and Epilogue bracket everything. Between them: five acts of narrative drama, a transitional scene bridging Act One and Act Two, and six standalone vignettes (Act Four) that together form a mosaic of the faiths the main acts could not contain.

PROLOGUE — THE PRESENT DAY

UNCLE, sixties, stirs a coffee he isn't drinking. COUSIN, thirties, stares at his phone. A half-eaten sandwich nobody wanted. The fluorescent hum of a hospital cafeteria — a room full of people waiting for something they cannot stop.

Neither of them wants to be here. Neither of them is leaving.

The Uncle tells the Cousin that Monica kept a Buddha on her windowsill her whole life — Catholic her whole life — and that she once said the two didn't contradict each other. He fumbles for the word. Animalism. Animism. Something to do with everything having a spirit — the river, the storm, the animal you hunted. He says he actually gets it. Like when you're somewhere quiet and it just feels like something's there.

The Cousin looks toward the hallway. Toward Room 14. "She still is."

Neither of them says anything after that.

Monica's room. A monitor. Slow. Steady. A small wooden cross on the wall. On the windowsill, a small ceramic Buddha that nobody quite remembers bringing. MONICA lies in the bed — in her eighties, beautiful the way very old people are beautiful: completely, honestly, without effort. Her eyes are open. She knows exactly where she is and is not afraid of it.

Her DAUGHTER sits closest, a rosary wound through her fingers. Her SON-IN-LAW stands at the foot of the bed, arms crossed — the specific helplessness of a man who solves problems for a living and cannot solve this one.

THEO, seventeen, sits beside Monica. Phone face-down. He has not looked away since they arrived.

When Monica asks him quietly — in what will be her last conversation — “Do you believe in anything?” — Theo has no answer. She closes her eyes. The monitor flatlines. And then the flat electronic tone bends and deepens and becomes something older than electronics, older than hospitals, older than any room a human being has ever died in.

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ACT ONE — THE FIRST QUESTION

Southern Africa · 70,000 BCE · Dialogue in Proto-Khoisan

KAEL is twenty years old. Watchful. A hunter at the edge of the firelight while his best friend DUMA performs at the center of it. What they have between them is the oldest thing in the film: two people who have known each other since birth, comfortable in each other's silence.

The next morning, the hunting party brings down two lions — a coordinated, terrifying attack survived through courage and luck. Duma throws his spear from suicidal range to save RAAN's life. The lion goes down.

Laughter floods through the group — the helpless, euphoric laughter of people who were prepared to die and are now understanding they don't have to.

Then: bees. In the chaos, a sting catches Duma below the jaw. NURU, the clan healer, treats it immediately — buchu herb, a procedure he has performed a hundred times. Routine. The hunting party walks home.

Kael notices first. The way Duma is walking. Something wrong. Duma's face is swelling — slowly, the way bread rises, his eye beginning to close, something happening beneath the skin that has no name in any language.

Nuru works fast. He tries everything he knows. The medicine is right. The medicine always works.

It is not working.

Duma shakes violently, suffocates. Then still.

Kael holds Duma's hand. Touches his face with one open palm. Gentle. Curious. Confused.

That night: a procession without ceremony, because ceremony has not been invented yet. Kael's sister SAYA strikes the clan's drum — a shallow depression in the earth, a heartbeat rising from the hollow ground. She paints Duma's face in red ochre and sings — wordless, structured, passed down through generations.

"Where is he going?"

"Somewhere."

"That's not an answer."

"No. It's the only answer."

She places Duma's spear beside him. Kael picks it up in protest. Saya puts her hand over his.

"So he can hunt where he is going."

"There is nowhere he is going. He is gone."

"Then why does it hurt so much to leave him with nothing?"

Kael has no answer. He sets the spear down.

Later — alone in the dark, speaking Duma's name to the stars, to whatever might be listening — Kael moves into a shallow cave and draws. Duma's face. Rough. Powerful. Unmistakably a portrait of love rather than art.

When he finishes, he presses his palm flat against the cave wall beside it.

The camera pushes slowly into the handprint until it fills the frame. Then: a match cut to a different handprint — same composition — on the wall of the Chauvet Cave in France, 30,000 years old. Real.

The oldest word for soul in any language means simply: breath. The last breath. The one that does not come back.

TRANSITION — BERINGIA: THE ICE BRIDGE

18,000 BCE · Dialogue in Proto-Na-Dene

The same Milky Way as Act One. Then a storm arrives from the west, swallowing the stars one by one.

A line of figures moves through the blizzard — men, women, children, the very old and the very young — dressed in heavy layered furs. At the center of the line: THE FIRE KEEPER. Both hands cupped around a hollowed bone packed with moss and fat, a single ember glowing inside.

His lips move — whether prayer or breath, it's impossible to say. The wind hits harder. The flame flattens. His hands close tighter. The flame holds.

TALA, young and strong, carries her infant KARR bound tight against her chest. She watches the hunters converge on a young mammoth at the edge of the herd. The LEAD HUNTER — a woman — directs the kill with practiced efficiency.

When it is done, she kneels and places both palms against the mammoth's flank. Still warm.

"Your last breath will strengthen ours. We will carry you into the world you never reached."

Night One.

The storm hits as the last light fails. No hunters. No shelter frame. No mammoth fat.

They stop where they are. Stone blades come out. People dig without being told — hollows scooped into the packed snow. Not deep. Just enough. A few degrees of difference between the air outside and the air inside. Between dying and not. The children go in first. Then the oldest. The dogs press in wherever there is space — not trained to, not told to. They know.

The Fire Keeper does not dig a hole. He lies flat on the ice at the center of the group, body curved around the hollowed bone, both hands cupped tight, his own body heat the fire tonight.

In her hollow, Tala holds Karr against her chest. She looks up through the hide at nothing. At where the Bear should be. The Bear does not come. She closes her eyes — not in prayer, but in the specific defeat of someone who has been cold too long to believe in anything warm.

Day Two.

They emerge. Reduced. They do not speak about the night. The old man is still walking but something has been taken from him. The Fire Keeper checks the ember. Still alive. They walk.

The man beside Tala speaks — not doctrine, personal testimony. His father's father crossed ice like this. The Bear never left them.

“Not everyone makes it through.”

“She does not promise us easy. She promises us through.”

Tala looks at Karr's face. Then up at the white.

And slowly, as if her looking calls it into being, the shape forms — THE GREAT MOTHER BEAR. Enormous. Made of weather. The blizzard itself taking form.

Tala does not wait for comfort. She makes the bargain first.

“Get him through this. Get us through this. And I will tell everyone that you are real. I will carry your name into whatever world is waiting on the other side of this ice. I will not let them forget you.”

The Bear's response is not a promise. It is one word.

“I know what you carry, Tala. I have always known. Walk.”

The man beside Tala does not see the Bear. Tala does not tell him. Some things belong only to the person who receives them.

The hunters return from behind — out of the white, sled loaded. No ceremony. They fall back into the line. Tala watches them come. She did not see the Bear bring them back. She did not need to.

Night Two.

A real shelter now — rough frame of spear shafts and portable bones, hides draped unevenly, gaps packed with snow and ice blocks. Built fast by exhausted people. Not engineered. Survived. Real flame from rendered mammoth fat. Thirty people with warmth that is chosen rather than merely endured.

In the corner, the old man's breathing slows. The woman beside him pulls him closer, covers him with an extra hide. His eyes find hers. Something passes between them that has no word in any language yet. He closes his eyes. She does not let go of him.

Tala sits against the far wall. Karr against her chest. Around her the shelter fills with the sounds of people finding sleep. She does not sleep. But it is different tonight — she is not awake from fear. She is awake from something that has no name yet.

She watches the flame. She made a bargain. The hunters came back. The shelter stands. The child breathes against her chest. She does not know if the Bear did this. She knows she will say that she did. That is enough. That is how it starts.

In the corner the old man's breathing stops. The woman beside him sits with it for a long moment. Then she pulls the hide up over him with the same care she used when he was alive. She will tell someone in the morning.

Dawn, Day Three.

The shelter comes down efficiently. Four people carry the old man out onto the ice. They dig. Frozen ground. It takes time. Nobody complains about the time. The woman's lips move over him. Then she turns, picks up her pack, rejoins the line.

The Fire Keeper takes his place at the center. The ember still alive. The line forms — smaller than yesterday. They walk.

Animism — the oldest belief system on Earth. The root from which every religion grew. Still practiced by hundreds of millions today.

ACT TWO — THE GOD MAKERS

The Fertile Crescent · c. 3,000 BCE · Dialogue in Sumerian

The first real city. Uruk. Dense mud-brick buildings on a flat plain between two rivers. At its center: a temple — the only building designed to be beautiful.

ENNA grinds grain outside her dwelling and watches a priest bestow a blessing on her husband DAGAN — and collect a contribution. She knows exactly what she is seeing.

When Dagan reports that the priests want a fifth of the harvest:

"Did the gods plant it? Did they water it? Did they drive the birds away at dawn?"

Enna takes her son LIDU to the temple. He is ten years old and immediately overwhelmed — by the statue of NINHURSAG, enormous, gilded, arms open, female. The first god humanity organized itself around was female.

To Lidu, Ninhursag comes alive. She speaks only to him — warm, intimate, the way his mother speaks when no one else is listening. She tells him she was here long before anyone gave her a name, that she did not come to frighten or to set one man above another.

Then something shifts in her face. Not fear — the awareness of something coming that cannot be stopped.

"My brother Enlil is coming. And what comes after him will look very different from what I am."

She looks at him the way a mother looks when she wants a child to remember something without being told to.

"Nothing that is loved is ever truly lost. But nothing lasts either."

Stone creeps back in as she speaks. Her eyes hold his until the last possible moment.

That night: Lidu dreams. ENLIL appears as a thousand-foot bull, lava leaking from his mouth, each word shaking the ground. Then, with deliberate calm, he reaches up and lifts the bull's head from his shoulders.

Beneath it: the High Priest. The same man from the temple. Speaking in his normal voice.

"He will care for you, your parents, the whole village. You must obey him, or be left to suffer."

He looks at the bull's head in his hand. Then slides it back on. The fire returns.

A drought follows. The fields go from green to yellow to brown. The frame drums in the temple fall silent. The High Priest announces that someone has broken the covenant. The crowd's fear finds its target: the KANA family.

Enna brings food to the Kana dwelling in the dark. Someone across the square sees her. She is brought before the High Priest.

"Without us, there is nothing between you and the dark."

"The dark was there before you named it."

He punishes her with public shaming. She walks out through the watching crowd. Her back straight. She does not run.

Three days later, the rain comes. The High Priest announces the gods are pleased.

Enna watches from the edge. She understands something complicated and true: it doesn't matter if it's real. It works.

At the river's edge at dusk, alone: the old ritual. No temple, no priest. She cups water in both hands. Lets it fall.

Lidu finds her. Sits beside her without being asked.

"Is this praying?"

"It's talking. To whatever is listening."

"Do you think anyone is listening?"

She looks at the stars in the water. "I think the question matters more than the answer."

Hinduism — 1.2 billion people. The oldest continuously practiced religion on Earth, already ancient when this city was built.

ACT THREE — THE ONE GOD

Babylon · c. 550 BCE · Dialogue in Biblical Hebrew, Aramaic, Babylonian Akkadian

The most powerful civilization the world has ever produced. The Jewish people live in exile within it. TOBIAS, twenty-five, watches the river every morning. Behind him, Babylon rises. He does not look at it.

Every morning he stops at the ISHTAR GATE — sixty feet of lapis lazuli blue, every surface covered with the god MARDUK and his dragon MUSHHUSHSHU. He has stopped here every morning for three years. Today something is different. He looks too long.

The dragon's eye moves.

Tobias stands at the base of the great Ziggurat. Marduk above him — vast, still — and on his shoulder, Mushhushshu, exactly as carved. Except breathing.

The dragon breathes fire. "Bow before the great god Marduk!" Then the fire dies. The voice shifts — smaller, almost conversational.

"Well. For about two thousand years anyway."

A pause.

"He was real to them. Every prayer, every sacrifice, every sleepless night when they looked up and needed something to hold onto — he was there. That is not nothing."

Tobias blinks. He is back at the gate. The dragon is stone. Almost against his will, he smiles.

In the narrow streets of the Jewish Quarter: up a stair, through a low doorway, into a room absolutely alive with scrolls. EZRA sits at the center. Writing. He is always here.

"You were at the river again."

"What are you writing today?"

"What I wrote yesterday. What I will write tomorrow. The beginning."

"You've written the beginning forty times."

"And I'll write it forty more until it's right. They can take our city. They cannot take our story."

In the market: a voice in Aramaic. "Not that one. The one next to it." NAIA — Babylonian, twenty-two, completely at home in a city that overwhelms him. At her throat: a small gold and lapis pendant of ISHTAR.

Tobias stares too long. The pendant catches the light and the world opens: a field impossibly green, Ishtar standing on a restless lion.

"Have courage, Tobias. She likes you. I am Ishtar — goddess of love, and war, and everything that lives between them. My name may change — Aphrodite, Venus — but I will be woven into every love story ever told. So go on. Don't be shy, beni."

The market reassembles.

On the rooftop at dusk: "Your god sounds lonely."

"Maybe that's the point. One god means one law. Everyone equal before the same thing."

"Or one god means one group of priests who decide what that law means."

He has no answer.

An interlude without dialogue — but not without image. Blank parchment fills the frame. A single drop of ink falls and spreads, finding the coastline of China the way water finds low ground. In the ink, gestural, suggested rather than drawn:

CONFUCIUS. An old man at a low table. He has written something. He looks at it. Something in his face shifts — not satisfaction. Surprise. As if the words arrived from somewhere he didn't expect.

A second drop falls. India. At the center of the subcontinent, beneath a fig tree:

THE BUDDHA. Eyes closed. Perfectly still. Everything around him moves. He does not move. He is the only still thing in the world.

A third drop. The Mediterranean. Greece.

SOCRATES on a rock above the water, lips moving. He stops mid-sentence. Sits with the absence of the answer. Then begins again. Still no answer. Still asking.

The camera pulls back. All three coastlines visible — still spreading, not yet touching. On the same parchment. Then the ink begins slowly to fade, absorbed back into the surface.

The camera moves into the texture of the fading parchment until it fills the frame — and a new mark appears. Fresh ink. Still wet. Ezra's hand moving across the page.

Tobias, reading: "Why does the same question arise in every land? At every moment of suffering?"

Ezra: "Because the question is not cultural, Tobias. It is human. It is what makes us human."

The Torah Ezra compiled — he read it. He knew it by heart.

Tobias stands at Ezra's doorway with his travel pack. "Come with me."

Ezra, still writing: "When I finish."

"How will you carry all of it?"

"Very carefully."

Tobias and Naia at the river at dusk. Farewell.

"Stay. There are gods enough here for both of us."

"It's not about the god. It's about the story. Without it I'm not anyone particular. I'm just a man in a city full of men."

"That's not nothing."

"No. But it's not enough."

He goes. She understands, even if she disagrees. This is what it costs to belong to a story.

Tobias looks back at Babylon one last time. Magnificent. Temporary. He looks up at the fading stars — same composition as every act before — and keeps walking.

Ezra's lamp still burns in the room behind him. The camera holds on it. The flame. The scroll beneath it. Ezra's hand still moving. The camera moves slowly into the words on the page — Hebrew characters, fresh ink, still wet.

Five hundred years pass in a single match cut.

Ezra's fresh ink to a worn community scroll in a small synagogue in Nazareth. The same letters. Different parchment. Darkened where ten thousand hands have touched it over generations. Community property. Owned by no one.

A MAN stands at the front of the synagogue and reads from Isaiah. The congregation listens differently than usual — the way a room listens when something heard a hundred times is suddenly being heard differently.

We never see his face. Only the scroll in his hands, the worn parchment, the letters passed hand to hand across five hundred years and fifteen hundred miles.

He finishes. Rolls the scroll with care. Hands it back. Sits. The room holds the silence a moment longer than expected. Then he rises and walks out into the light.

ACT THREE CODA — THE TEKTON'S WORKSHOP

Nazareth · c. 20 CE

The camera finds a hand first. The same hands.

Dark olive skin. Short blunt fingers. The deep built callus of a lifetime beginning in childhood. A stone chisel against pale limestone.

The Torah Ezra compiled — he read it. He knew it by heart.

The room: undressed limestone walls. Packed earth floor. One shaft of morning light.

We never see his face. His hands. His feet in worn leather sandals. The back of his head. His shoulders — lean, the leanness of endurance built over years.

He is approximately five feet five inches tall. He would disappear in a modern crowd. He is, by every outward measure, unremarkable.

Perhaps that is the point.

He sets his chisel down. Stretches his hands — those dark, calloused, scarred hands — open in front of him. Looks at them.

His father's hands.

He picks up his cloak. Walks out into the courtyard. Into the light. We never see his face.

*Jesus of Nazareth · c. 4 BCE to c. 30 CE · 2.4 billion people — the Son of God.
Whether divine, prophet, or man, his impact on humanity is beyond calculation.*

ACT FOUR — THE LONG GOODBYE

Various Eras · Six Vignettes

Act Four moves largely without dialogue. Six standalone vignettes — each one a civilization at a turning point, a faith in its final or defining hour, rendered in image and music alone.

Each transition is distinct: a flame match cut, a sound-led shift, a crowd roar dropping into cold wind, a drum answering a drum across centuries. No two the same.

VIGNETTE ONE — THE LAST GREEK

Greece · 4th Century CE

An old woman approaches a temple with offerings — fruit, flowers, a small clay figurine of Athena. She has made this walk ten thousand times.

The figurine comes to life. Athena looks at the old woman with love. Then speaks — not coldly, just clearly, the way someone speaks when they know time is short.

"The Greek pantheon. Over four hundred of us. Worshiped for approximately eighteen hundred years. This temple will be a church by spring, banned by imperial decree."

"I gave them philosophy. Democracy. The capacity to reason. They built the Parthenon in my honor. It will become a church. Then a mosque. Then a ruin."

"And yet everything they used to build those things — the reason, the beauty, the search for truth — that came from me. That part they kept. They just forgot where they got it."

Stone again. A young Roman soldier sits at the entrance, a small new cross at his neck. The old woman enters. We cannot hear what she says. We understand it completely.

Hellenism — today practiced by a small but growing number worldwide.

VIGNETTE TWO — THE CAVE

Mount Hira, Hejaz Region · 610 CE

Inside: a small oil lamp. Its flame bends in a breath of wind, then steadies.

Beside the lamp, a simple cloth — rumpled, recently abandoned, still holding the faint shape of someone who was here. Who is no longer here.

On the wind, faintly: not words. The specific quality of a human voice that has just received something it will spend the rest of its life trying to carry.

The first word that came to him in this cave was a command. One word. Ancient. Absolute.

Iqra. Read. Recite. Receive.

The camera moves into the flame — and match cuts to Mecca at night.

A single point of light becomes thousands, then tens of thousands. The great mosque reveals itself, ancient stones lit from within by something that has been burning here for fourteen centuries.

Wordless voices rise — not organized, not coordinated — the way light rises, from one source then another.

The Kaaba: black draped stone at the center of everything. Simple. Absolute. Here before the city. Here before the minarets.

The tawaf has begun — thousands of white-clad figures moving counterclockwise in slow, continuous, living rings. A human galaxy, turning. Unhurried. Inevitable.

The camera rises: mosque, city, desert — the same sky that was above the cave on the mountain, the same stars, the same darkness that holds everything.

Two million people. One direction. One center.

From one man in a cave to this.

His wife believed him. She became the first Muslim. Her name was Khadijah. Islam — 1.9 billion followers. The fastest growing religion on Earth.

VIGNETTE THREE — THE FIRST MATCH

Izumo, Japan · The Age Before the Islands Were Decided

The sea has no name. The shore is black rock and white foam.

Two figures stand at the water's edge — not men. Too still. Too large. TAKEMIKAZUCHI, god of thunder and conquest, and TAKEMINAKATA, god of wind and water. Between them: the question of who this land belongs to.

No words. There are no words yet for what this is.

The contest — gripping, transforming, overwhelming — ends with Takeminakata on his knees.

"Let me live. I will go to the mountain lake. To Suwa. I will hold myself there. I will not leave."

Takemikazuchi releases him. Then stamps the earth. The ground shakes. Salt thrown across the rock. The sky resolves. The land is decided.

Match cut to: Ryogoku Kokugikan, Tokyo, present day.

Two rikishi face each other on the dohyo. They reach down, lift a handful of salt, throw it across the clay. Raise one foot. High. Pause. Stamp it down.

We have seen these actions before — on a black shore, before the world was finished. The same gestures. The same purpose.

Shinto — 300 million followers worldwide. The oldest continuous religious tradition in Japan. The sacredness of the world, exactly as it is.

VIGNETTE FOUR — THE FINAL DRUID

Mona, Wales · 60 CE

Ancient oaks — as old as the tradition being spoken beneath them.

A DRUID ELDER pours his entire tradition into a YOUNG APPRENTICE, because there is no other container for it. The boy's lips move with the elder's words. Some of it lands. Some of it slips.

Almost is not all.

"You are the vessel, boy. Not the stone. Not the earth. You. If it does not live in you it lives nowhere."

The full weight of it lands on the boy for the first time.

Then — slowly — a branch above him descends. Not with force. The way an arm reaches toward a child who is frightened. It finds his right hand and holds it. From below, a root rises and curls around his left.

He is held. From the sky and from the earth simultaneously. Not trapped. Steadied.

He is inside the oak.

Not a dream — the grove is gone, the elder is gone, and around him in every direction the rings of the tree radiate outward: hundreds, then thousands, each one a year, each year a generation of Druids standing in this grove, speaking these same words.

He presses his palms flat against the nearest ring. Where his hands touch, light blazes — gold and amber pouring up through his palms. The accumulated presence of everyone who ever stood in this grove and believed.

Then the voice from the wood itself:

"Little one. What you carry is older than this grove. Older than me. Stone cannot hold it. The earth cannot hold it. Only you."

The grove returns. The branch lifts. The root withdraws. The boy looks at the elder. Takes a breath.

And begins again. This time the words come right. Every one of them.

The Druids wrote nothing down. Their entire tradition lived only in memory. When the last Druids died, everything they knew died with them.

VIGNETTE FIVE — THE ZOROASTRIAN FIRE

Persia · 7th Century CE

A sacred flame burns in a bronze vessel on a stone altar. It has been burning continuously for over a thousand years.

THE FIRE PRIEST enters in white garments and the padan — a small cloth over his mouth and nose, to prevent his breath from contaminating the fire. This is what he does. What his father did. What his father's father did.

Then the flame changes.

Not dramatically — a deepening, a quality of light that has no name in any language. The priest goes absolutely still. Not words, not visions — something older than both. A knowing that moves through him like heat through stone.

He understands.

He looks toward the door. Outside: the distant sound of armies. Not close. But coming.

He wraps the vessel carefully — the specific unhurried deliberateness of a man who has received clear instruction. Every fold exact. Every movement a form of prayer.

He lifts it. Holds it against his chest. Walks out into the burning city.

At the riverbank: a small boat. The city behind him is orange now, lit from within by something that is not sacred.

He boards. Sets the vessel down with both hands. Picks up the oar.

Then: the dock.

A WOMAN appears at the water's edge, breathless. Behind her, two children. She has a bundle under one arm — everything she owns. She sees the boat. She sees him.

She does not scream. She does not beg. She simply holds up her hand.

Wait.

The priest stops rowing. One beat.

He looks at her face. The children. The flame wrapped against his chest, still burning. The sounds of the army — very close now.

He looks at her once more.

Then he rows.

He does not look back. He cannot afford that yet.

In his eyes: not fear. Certainty. The fire does not go out.

Smash cut to: the current Atash Behram, Udvada, India. The holiest Zoroastrian fire in the world — carried out of Persia by refugees over twelve hundred years ago. Still burning. The camera holds on the flame.

That fire is still burning today. Fewer than 200,000 followers remain. But the daf drum does not stop.

VIGNETTE SIX — THE MAYAN CODEX

Mani, Yucatan · July 1562

A MAYAN PRIEST surrounded by the codices — folded bark paper in dense, vivid, color-saturated writing. The accumulated knowledge of three thousand years.

A SPANISH FRIAR across the courtyard, his quill moving constantly. He believes sincerely he is witnessing the destruction of the devil's work.

The priest looks at his books. Then at the fire. He makes a decision.

He picks up the first codex, admires its specific colors, its specific beauty — and places it in the fire. Then the second.

By dawn the fire has consumed everything except what the priest hid. Four codices will survive. Of thousands.

The priest stands before the cold ash. His face utterly still.

Then one sound: a single sharp exhaled breath. The specific sound of grief that has no language left.

THE FIRES OF ACT FOUR — CODA

The fires of Act Four edited together against absolute darkness.

The Greek offering flame. The Zoroastrian sacred fire. The Mayan bonfire.

Fire to fire to fire. Each one briefly visible. Each one beautiful. Each one gone.

Then complete darkness. Then a single ember — still glowing. The camera holds on it.

Some things survive.

The ember fades. Slowly.

EPILOGUE — THE PRESENT DAY

4,200 religious traditions currently practiced on Earth. None of them agree on the answer. All of them are still asking the question.

The hospital monitor again. We return to Room 14. Monica lies still. The machines have gone silent.

On the television in the corner, a press conference — a Secretary of War quoting what he believes is scripture. A reporter notes it is dialogue from a Hollywood film. The camera moves past it.

Theo stayed. While everyone else went to the hallway, he stayed. He is holding her hand. Both his hands around hers. Looking at her face. His eyes full — not crying yet, something before crying, something that has no name.

We have seen this before. In the grass of the African savanna. Seventy thousand years ago. The same gesture. The same refusal. The same love that has no answer and keeps going anyway.

He moves to the window. Outside: a parking lot, streetlights, the ordinary world at night. And above it, stars — not many, but enough. The ones that refused to be drowned out.

The score begins. A single human voice — wordless, low — the same voice that opened the film. A second joins. Then a third. Then a thousand. Building from one person to all people, from the first campfire to the full orchestration of everything humanity has ever believed and doubted and built and burned and begun again.

Then it strips back. One by one. Until there is only the single voice again. The first voice. The oldest voice. Silence. One star. Held.

The question Kael asked beside a fire 70,000 years ago has never been answered. It has never stopped being asked.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE WORLD OF THE FILM

Before the Gods does not visualize God. It does not argue for or against belief. It renders, with full cinematic commitment, what it felt like to be human — afraid, alive, curious, and in love — at the moment each civilization built something to hold onto.

The animation style is heightened photorealism: not cartoon, not live-action, but a visual register capable of rendering the firelight of 70,000 BCE and the fluorescent glare of a modern hospital with equal truthfulness.

The gods, when they appear, emerge from within the belief of the characters — Ninhursag from within a child's awe, Ishtar from the pendant of a woman Tobias is falling in love with, the Great Mother Bear from within the terror and faith of a woman crossing a frozen continent.

Each act has its own sonic identity — Proto-Khoisan percussion, Sumerian temple drums, Persian daf — building through the film toward a full orchestral score that, in the final minutes, weaves every tradition's musical thread into one.

The Milky Way is the film's recurring visual anchor. It appears in every act — the same sky, seen by different eyes, across 70,000 years. It is the one thing that has not changed. The thing all of them looked up at. The frame within the frame.

KEY CHARACTERS

KAEL — Act One

Southern Africa, 70,000 BCE

Twenty years old. Watchful by nature — the hunter who observes before he acts. His love for Duma is the oldest thing in the film. When Duma dies of an allergic reaction — suddenly, randomly, without meaning — Kael becomes the first person in human history to ask: where did he go? He doesn't have the concept of death yet. He has the feeling. The film begins with that feeling and does not leave it.

ENNA — Act Two

Uruk, 3,000 BCE

Thirty years old. A grain farmer who sees through institutional religion with clear eyes — but also understands, by the end, that what it gives people is real, even if what it takes is unjust. She is the film's skeptic. She is not wrong. She is not the enemy of belief. She is the part of the human mind that asks: who benefits?

TOBIAS — Act Three

Babylon, 550 BCE

Twenty-five years old. A man in exile — from his land, from certainty, from the comfort of belonging to something unquestioned. His friendship with Ezra and his love for Naia are the film's central romance of ideas: what does it cost to belong to a story? What do you lose when you leave it? What do you lose when you stay?

THEO — Prologue / Epilogue

Present Day

Seventeen years old. He has no answers. He is the audience — the modern person who has inherited 70,000 years of human searching and doesn't know what to do with it. His silence at Monica's bedside, and his staying after everyone else has gone, is the film's emotional conclusion: the question doesn't require an answer. The love is the answer.

THEMES

Before the Gods is about the specific human experience of not knowing — and the extraordinary things people build in that space. It does not take sides. It does not resolve. Its argument, if it has one, is this: the fact that human beings have always asked the same question, in every civilization, in every language, across 70,000 years of separation, is itself the most remarkable thing about us.

The film tracks several through-lines across its entire span: fire (carried, protected, threatened, extinguished, still burning); the Milky Way (witnessed by every act's characters, unchanged across 70,000 years); hands (Kael's handprint, the mammoth hunter's palms on the animal's flank, Theo holding Monica's hands in both of his); and the drum (the Pit drum of Act One becomes the temple drum of Act Two becomes the daf of Act Four — the same heartbeat, different names).

The television set in the epilogue — a Secretary of War misquoting a Hollywood film as scripture — is not a polemic. It is an honest observation: the same human impulse that caused Kael to press his palm against a cave wall 70,000 years ago is still operating. It has always been operating. The shapes it takes change. The impulse doesn't.

COMPARABLE WORKS

The audience for *Before the Gods* is everyone who made *Flee* an Oscar contender and everyone who made *The Ten Commandments* one of the highest-grossing films in history. That audience has never been given the same film. This is that film.

Flee (2021) — prestige adult animation, awards circuit, unflinching emotional honesty, subject matter that mainstream animation does not touch.

Waltz with Bashir (2008) — serious animated exploration of history, memory, and moral reckoning. Demonstrated that animation can carry adult weight.

Wolfwalkers (2020) — mythological, lyrical, visually distinctive. Cartoon Saloon, Irish co-production. Signals the Screen Ireland co-production route and the film's natural home in the prestige animation ecosystem.

The Breadwinner (2017) — Cartoon Saloon / Angelina Jolie. Adult subject matter, spiritual dimension, international co-production. Oscar nominated. The clearest precedent for Before the Gods as a financing structure.

Before the Gods is not content. It is a cultural event — the kind of prestige asset that defines a platform's identity for a decade. There is not another film like it in development anywhere.

CO-PRODUCTION STRATEGY

Before the Gods is structured for international co-production, with natural entry points in three jurisdictions:

IRELAND

Screen Ireland and Section 481 tax incentive (up to 32% on qualifying Irish spend). Cartoon Saloon is Irish. The prestige animated feature tradition in Ireland — The Secret of Kells, Song of the Sea, Wolfwalkers, The Breadwinner — maps directly onto the tone and ambition of Before the Gods.

UNITED KINGDOM

BFI, Film4, BBC Films, BAFTA-qualifying international scope. The film's transatlantic subject matter and English-language framing make it a natural fit for UK co-financing.

CANADA

Telefilm Canada, the CBC, and provincial funds. Canada has a strong tradition of supporting prestige animation with international scope and co-production agreements with both Ireland and the UK.

ABOUT THE WRITER

DOUG OLEAR is an actor and writer based in the United States. He has worked extensively in film and television, including as a cast member on *The Wire*. He was trained at the Stella Adler Conservatory, where his class included students from over a dozen countries — an experience that shaped his understanding of how different cultures carry the same questions.

He was raised Catholic, in an Orthodox Jewish neighborhood, by a mother of deep faith and a father who was agnostic. *Before the Gods* grew from his lifelong fascination with the paradox at the center of religious belief: that billions of people — each certain of their own truth — cannot all be right, and yet the need that drives each of them is identical.

He is open to working with an outside director. He believes the right director — with the right visual sensibility and the right emotional relationship to the material — will make *Before the Gods* more than he can make it alone.

PROJECT STATUS

Screenplay: Complete. WGA registered (2341477). U.S. Copyright registered (1-15159914181).

Website / Pitch Deck: Live at beforethegods.com. Password-protected industry pitch deck at beforethegods.com/deck.html (password: GODS2026).

Visual Development: Eighteen concept images generated across all acts. Comic book adaptation in development as both a pitch artifact and an independent copyright vehicle — two-issue limited series (*Before the Gods: The Question* / *Before the Gods: The Answers*), to be professionally printed for in-room pitch use.

Target Platforms: Netflix, Apple TV+. Secondary targets: A24, Film4, BBC Films, Screen Ireland co-production route.

Talent: Open to attachment. Discussions ongoing regarding transatlantic talent with European co-production reach.

LIMITED SERIES

Before the Gods is also available as a seven-episode limited series. The series format allows each civilization its own episode, expanding the emotional depth of every act while preserving the film's through-line: one question, never answered, asked across 70,000 years.

Pitch line: "Seven Episodes. Eleven Civilizations. 70,000 Years. One Question. Never Answered."

Budget: \$28–35 Million total / \$4–5 Million per episode.

Episode 1 — The First Question: Prologue + Southern Africa, 70,000 BCE. Monica's deathbed. Kael. Duma. The first question.

Episode 2 — The Ice Bridge: Beringia, 18,000 BCE. The mammoth hunt. The Great Mother Bear. The fire keeper.

Episode 3 — The God Makers: Mesopotamia, c. 3,000 BCE. Enna. Lidu. Ninhursag. Enlil.

Episode 4 — They Cannot Take Our Story: Babylon, c. 550 BCE + Nazareth, c. 20 CE. Ezra. Tobias. Naia. Marduk. Jesus.

Episode 5 — The Long Goodbye Part One: 4th Century CE / 610 CE / 712 CE. Greece. Islam. Japan (Shinto).

Episode 6 — The Long Goodbye Part Two: 60 CE / 7th Century CE / 1562 CE. Druids. Zoroastrianism. The Mayan Codex.

Episode 7 — The Question Is Enough: Present Day. Theo. Monica. The Milky Way. The Epilogue.

Full series breakdown available at beforethegods.com/before-the-gods-series.html

THE PRODUCTION LANDSCAPE

The production landscape has changed. Jon Erwin's *The Old Stories: Moses* (Prime Video, May 2026) — a three-episode biblical epic spanning ancient Egypt and the Sinai — was filmed in one week on a single Los Angeles soundstage with 100 crew, using AI-generated environments and virtual production. Budget: under \$5 million per episode.

Before the Gods targets the same production revolution, applied to heightened photorealistic animation — a workflow that delivers complete creative control over every era, every civilization, every frame. What would have cost \$80–100 million a decade ago is now a \$25–40 million film.

"The question has never been answered.

It has never stopped being asked."

BEFORE THE GODS

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